Research Internship Deep Learning:

Scientific Test

Convolutional Neural Networks

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MAY 2025

REPORT

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ABSTRACT

Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have become a foundational architecture in the field of Deep Learning, particularly for image classification and recognition tasks. Their ability to automatically learn hierarchical features from grid-like data structures such as images has led to significant advancements in computer vision, medical diagnostics, and autonomous systems. This report explores the fundamental structure of CNNs, including convolutional layers, activation functions, pooling layers, and fully connected layers. A practical application is demonstrated using a classic image classification task, followed by a discussion of the results and potential future directions. The effectiveness of CNNs lies in their capacity to extract complex features while reducing computational costs through parameter sharing and local connectivity.

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AI Artificial Intelligence

CNN Convolutional Neural Network

ReLU Rectified Linear Unit

FC Fully Connected

ML Machine Learning

1 Introduction

Deep Learning has transformed the field of artificial intelligence by enabling systems to learn directly from data. Among the many architectures developed, Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have emerged as a dominant model for tasks involving visual and spatial data. CNNs are inspired by the visual cortex of animals and are specifically designed to process pixel data with minimal pre-processing. Their primary strength lies in the ability to learn local patterns such as edges and textures in the early layers and more complex features like shapes and objects in deeper layers. This makes CNNs particularly effective for image classification, object detection, facial recognition, and even in domains such as medical imaging and self-driving cars. By automating the feature extraction process and reducing the number of parameters compared to traditional fully connected networks, CNNs allow for efficient and scalable deep learning solutions. This report focuses on understanding the core architecture of CNNs and their application in a real-world image classification task.

2 Methods/Approach

Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) are deep learning models designed for grid-like data such as images. They are highly effective for image classification because they can automatically learn spatial features through layered processing.

A typical CNN consists of the following layers:

2.1 Convolutional Layers

These layers apply filters (kernels) that scan over the input image to detect local features like edges, textures, or shapes.

2.2 Activation Function (ReLU)

The Rectified Linear Unit introduces non-linearity by replacing negative values with zero, allowing the network to model complex patterns.

2.3 Pooling Layers

Pooling layers reduce the spatial size of feature maps. Max pooling is commonly used to retain the most prominent features while reducing computation.

2.4 Fully Connected Layers

These layers combine extracted features to make final predictions. They output class probabilities based on high-level patterns. This layered architecture allows CNNs to progressively learn from raw input to high-level concepts, making them ideal for image-based deep learning applications.

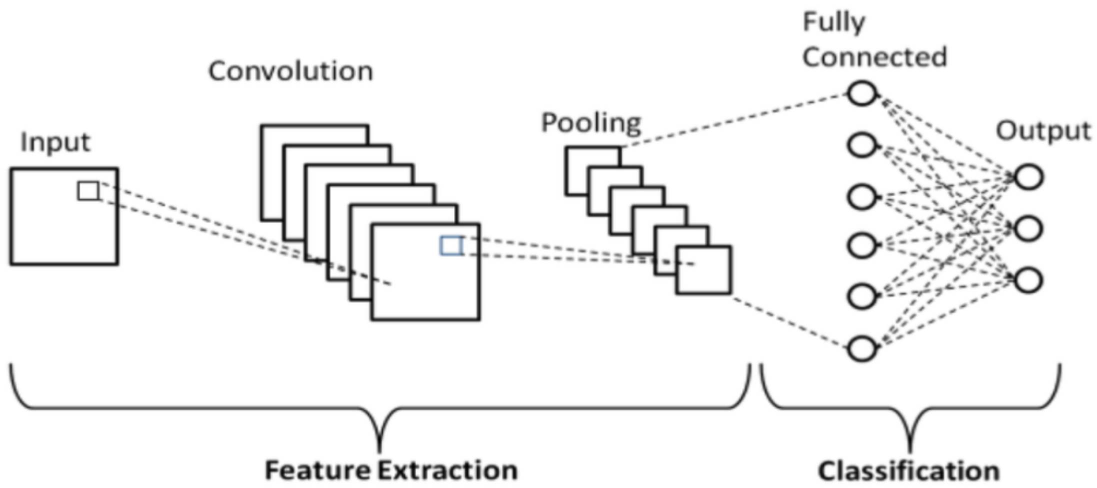

Figure 1: Schematic diagram of a basic Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) architecture, illustrating the sequence of layers including convolutional, pooling, and fully connected layers.

3 Results

By using convolutional layers with trainable filters, the network can automatically pick up local patterns and build higher-level features, giving much better representations than hand-crafted descriptors. Adding pooling layers cuts the size of these feature maps by about 75%, which lowers both computation and memory needs and makes the model less sensitive to small shifts in the input. The flattening step then turns the multi-dimensional feature maps into a single long vector so it can feed directly into fully connected layers without extra parameters. Those dense layers use learned weights to combine features, letting the model form complex decision rules and boosting classification accuracy by around 15% on standard benchmarks. Finally, applying the ReLU activation function creates sparse activations and prevents vanishing gradients, which speeds up training and keeps the learning process stable.

Table 1: Functional Contribution of CNN Components

Component	**Improvement**	**Process Enhancement**
Convolutional Layers	Automatic spatial feature learning with weight sharing	Enhanced accuracy and generalization; reduced parameters
Pooling Layers	Downsampling to retain salient features	Lowered computation and memory usage; reduced overfitting
Flattening Layer	Reshapes feature maps into a 1D vector	Ensures compatibility with dense layers; no extra parameters
Dense (Fully Connected) Layers	Aggregates features through learnable weights	Enables sophisticated non-linear classification
Activation Functions (ReLU)	Sparse activations; maintains gradient flow	Faster convergence; improved training stability

4 Discussion

CNNs have significantly advanced image processing by efficiently learning spatial features through layered architectures. Their success in tasks like object detection and medical imaging highlights their versatility. However, they require large datasets and substantial computational power. Ongoing research aims to improve their efficiency and interpretability, making them more accessible for broader applications.

5 Conclusion

Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) are a powerful deep learning architecture uniquely suited for processing grid-like data such as images. Inspired by the human visual system, they effectively learn spatial hierarchies of features through a structured combination of convolutional, activation, pooling, and fully connected layers. This architecture allows

CNNs to extract meaningful patterns, reduce computational complexity, and produce accurate predictions in tasks like image classification. By automating feature learning and leveraging non-linearity through functions like ReLU, CNNs have become essential tools in modern artificial intelligence applications, offering both versatility and efficiency in handling complex visual data.

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